



The Humanitas Institute

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Seacoast Classical Academy
School Website: <https://seacoastclassical.org/>

December 22, 2025

Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

ACCS Member School

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools ACCS or the Society for Classical Learning SCL is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Executive Summary

Seacoast Classical Academy (Newton, NH) demonstrates a strong core alignment with classical-education principles, anchored by a Hillsdale College K-12 curriculum, a Great Books-oriented orientation, and a deliberate emphasis on virtue, truth, and beauty. The school foregrounds formation of character, rigorous content, and a family-centered governance model that places parents as primary partners in education. Pedagogy includes Socratic discussion, memory work, and deliberate language-learning (Latin roots, Greek/Latin study), alongside a memory-rich lower-school culture featuring singing and recitation. The faculty pages portray experienced, virtue-minded leadership and teachers who view themselves as part of a "living curriculum." The school also emphasizes family partnership and open-parent interactions (parent tours, observations, and parent-led engagement). Taken together, the six-category assessment yields a broadly classical profile with particular strength in Curriculum, Pedagogy, Faculty, and Parents & Community; the Religious and Metaphysical Foundations sentiment is present but not anchored in explicit theology or liturgical practice. Overall: CLASSICAL, with Element 1 showing some readiness but lacking explicit liturgical/theological framing.

Key evidentiary highlights: - Curriculum: Hillsdale K-12 Curriculum; Singapore Math; Core Knowledge; Great Books and primary sources; study of Latin roots; emphasis on Western tradition and primary historical sources. Evidence appears across the Academics and Curriculum pages.

- Pedagogy: Explicit mention of Socratic discussion, seminars, debates, rhetoric training, and upper-school oratory; lower-school singing and memory-building. - Faculty: Faculty bios emphasize virtue, mentorship, and "experienced leadership," with the Principal and Curriculum Director foregrounded. - Parents & Community: Mission emphasizes family rights and parental primacy; explicit statements about parent involvement and observations; open-parent interactions and governance engagement. - Religious/Metaphysical Foundations: Emphasis on Western/traditional virtues and moral formation; limited explicit theology or liturgical practices in public materials.

Category-by-category snapshot, followed by the abstract.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school describes a virtue-centered, Western-tradition orientation and moral formation, including explicit statements about virtue and moral order, and the Logos in the context of classical education. The Mission references "traditions of moral and civic virtue with a central and recurring emphasis on Western and foundational American principles." - The public materials emphasize truth, goodness, beauty as real ideals (via virtue and Western tradition framing) but stop short of explicit theological anchoring or liturgical practices. The presence of virtue-based language is clear, yet theology and liturgical communal practices are not foregrounded.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: virtue, truth, moral order, Western tradition, moral formation, Logos, understanding of virtue. Examples appear in the mission and virtue sections. -

Negative keywords present: not explicitly present; terms such as “secular ethics,” “values-neutral,” or “liturgical” are not evident in the public-facing materials. The absence is notable rather than presence of explicit negatives.

Why this rating - The school demonstrates classical sensibilities in virtue, moral order, and truth-centered aims, but does not foreground theology, liturgical practices, or explicit sacred rituals in public communications. Thus, it sits between classical and non-theological, landing in SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL for this category.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The mission emphasizes formation of virtue and human excellence, not mere information. The phrasing “we impart knowledge and develop understanding through the examination and synthesis of that knowledge; we teach our scholars how to think critically, not what to think” signals formation and critical thinking over simple information transfer. - The curriculum and philosophy articulate a pursuit of truth, goodness, and beauty (with reference to Western tradition and virtue); there is a clear telos toward wisdom and moral formation rather than job-centric outcomes. - The school explicitly frames education as formation within a liberal-arts, classical framework, including Great Books and a foundational emphasis on human flourishing.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: formation, virtue, human flourishing, wisdom, truth, beauty, great conversation/conversation, moral imagination, classical heritage.

- Negative keywords present: none detected (no explicit emphasis on “college/career readiness” or work-skills focus in public statements).

Why this rating - The school clearly positions education as formation toward virtue and wisdom, with a classical telos aligned to the Great Conversation and the liberal arts, satisfying CLASSICAL criteria for this category.

Element 3: School Curriculum — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The Hillsdale College K-12 Curriculum is the core framework, licensed for use in the school; the content includes a broad liberal-arts program with English/Language Arts, Math (Singapore Math), History/Civics, Science, Foreign Languages, Art, Music, and Physical Education. - Great Books and positive engagement with primary sources appear in communications about classical education and in teacher statements (“lover of the Great Books”). The curriculum emphasizes the Great Conversation and the use of primary sources in history and civics. - Specific curricular components highlighted include grammar, logic, rhetoric (Trivium) and quadrivium components, Latin/Greek roots, and a content-rich Western canon; there is explicit mention of Latin instruction, classical languages, and classical history/civilization content. - The curriculum also foregrounds Core Knowledge components and a primary emphasis on primary sources/history to complement a content-rich classical program.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: Seven Liberal Arts (grammar, logic, rhetoric), Trivium/Quadrivium, Great Books, primary sources/original texts, Western civilization, history & civics, Core Knowledge, Latin/Latin roots, integration of arts and sciences, literature, and inquiry-based components. - Negative keywords present: not observed; no explicit shift away from history to social studies or project-based emphasis; no major deviation from classic-canon curriculum signals in public materials.

Why this rating - The curriculum is explicitly built on canonical classical elements (Liberal Arts, Great Books, Trivium/Quadrivium, Western canon) and is reinforced by a Hillsdale licensure, supporting a CLASSICAL categorization for Curriculum.

Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Upper grades: Socratic discussion, seminars, debates, and rhetoric training; students are prepared to give speeches and use rhetoric. This is a hallmark of classical pedagogy, especially in upper grades. - Lower grades: Singing, chanting, and memory-work culture; regular review to deepen memory and delight; a contemplative and restful aspect in lines with scholé-like practices. - Across grades, there is evidence of a “living curriculum” feel through faculty and leadership emphasis on virtue and classical pedagogy; the curriculum is content-rich and designed to train students in knowledge, understanding, and critical thinking.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: Socratic, seminars, debates, rhetoric, speeches, memory-work/recitation, chanting, scholé (educational restfulness/contemplation is implied in lower-school pedagogy), integration of contemplation with rigorous content, Great Books orientation. - Negative keywords present: not evident; no explicit emphasis on purely project-based or constructivist pedagogy dominating (the public materials emphasize direct instruction of content in a classical framework).

Why this rating - Pedagogy integrates Socratic inquiry and rhetoric with a strong memory-based lower-school culture, consistent with CLASSICAL pedagogy. The presence of upper-grade Socratic/seminar work and lower-grade chant/memory aligns with the classical model, yielding a CLASSICAL rating for Pedagogy.

Element 5: School Faculty — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Faculty communications emphasize virtue-based leadership and mentorship; bios describe experienced leaders (Principal, Curriculum & Instruction Director) with a focus on guiding teachers and scholars toward classical education goals. - The faculty are described as living the mission and forming the core of the school; the public-facing materials present a portrait of educators as role models and co-learners who shape the school culture. The Head of School job description highlights responsibilities that emphasize culture, virtue, and teacher development.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: mentor/teacher as model, virtue-based leadership, living curriculum, portrait of teacher, harmonious teacher-student relationship, scholarly leadership. - Negative keywords present: not overt; no mentions of “teacher as facilitator only” without classical substance, or of purely numerical performance emphasis.

Why this rating - The public materials frame faculty as virtuous, experienced, and central to the school’s classical mission, aligning with CLASSICAL expectations for the Faculty category.

Element 6: Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The mission foregrounds family rights and the parental role as primary decision-makers; the school emphasizes partnership with families and sees parents as co-educators in the classical education project. - Classroom observations and parent engagement are encouraged; families are invited to participate, and there are explicit references to family formation and parent-led engagement opportunities (e.g., information sessions, tours, and ongoing communications). - The public materials consistently emphasize parental involvement and transparency, reinforcing a culture of home-school collaboration central to classical pedagogy.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: partnership with families, parent as co-teacher, parental formation/engagement, home-school collaboration, family rights, open visits, teacher-parent collaboration. - Negative keywords present: not observed; no evidence of consumer-model parent roles or minimal parent involvement.

Why this rating - The school strongly foregrounds parental partnership and family rights, aligning well with CLASSICAL expectations for Parents & Community.

What Would Move the Needle

- If aiming to strengthen the RELIGIOUS AND METAPHYSICAL FOUNDATIONS category to a full CLASSICAL rating, the school could explicitly articulate theological integrations or liturgical practices (even if modest) within public communications, or clearly anchor moral formation in a defined theological/philosophical framework beyond Western-tradition virtues.
- While not required to achieve CLASSICAL across all six categories, explicit emphasis on liturgical practices, sacred traditions, or direct theology (in public materials) would push Element 1 from SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL toward CLASSICAL.

Note: Given the current public-materials emphasis, the aggregate assessment remains CLASSICAL, with Element 1 being the primary area where the rhetoric is strongest in virtue and truth/beauty but weakest on explicit theology/liturgy.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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